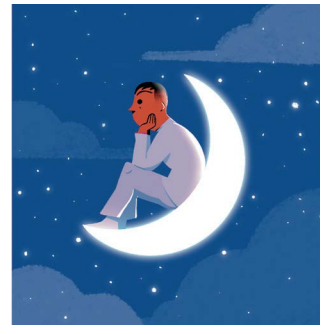
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

What will kill us faster if we don't get enough of it? Air, water and food naturally sit at the top of our hierarchy of needs. Sleep tends to come way behind. That's the way we think and how we conduct our lives. Because its deficit does not kill immediately, Indians have taken to habitually economising on sleep. In a May 2023 study of those above 40 years of age across 20 Indian states and Union territories, the Agewell Foundation, a Delhi-based civil society organisation, found that one entire half of those surveyed suffer from sleep disorders of one sort or another. Nearly 70 per cent of them were sleeping less than six hours. In urban areas, an alarming 75 per cent were sleeping less than 5-6 hours. Another extensive study done early this year by an Indian social media platform corroborated the essential point there: across all age groups, over 61 per cent reported sleeping less than six hours. A 2023 paper, which reviewed 100 sleep studies, found one in four Indians to be afflicted outright with insomnia, which is sleep poverty in terms of both quantity and quality. Experts regard a minimum of seven hours of sleep as bare essential and eight to nine hours as ideal for healthy living. Indians, clearly, are suffering from an enormous sleep deficit.



This collective insomniac behaviour is raising an alarm for our physical and mental health. Global studies routinely put India on top of the list of countries with a chronic sleep deficit. This means we are looking at one of the world's biggest armies of sleep-deprived humans, heading bleary-eyed into serious health crises. A wealth of recent scientific research indicates that sleep, rather than being a state of inactivity, is one of the most creative and vital times for the human body. In fact, the body turns into a buzzing service workshop at the molecular and neural levels during normal nocturnal sleep. Tissues get repaired and remade, memory gets solidified, hormones keep every metabolic function ship-shape, the brain's 'housekeeping system' drains away toxins whose build-up could lead to Alzheimer's, the phase of deep or slow-wave sleep restores energy. When we deprive ourselves of the recommended eight or nine hours of quality sleep, we are routinely denied the restorative effects of this nightly system reboot. And India is fast becoming a groggy nation. Dr J.C. Suri, founder of the first national sleep clinic at Delhi's Safdarjung Hospital, tells INDIA TODAY: "Good sleep has become a luxury." Bengaluru-based psychiatrist Satish Ramaiah estimates that some 30-40 per cent of our population suffers from insomnia at some point in their life.

Why are Indians sleeping less? The reasons range from livelihood issues to behavioural patterns getting retuned to fit an 'always-on' digital universe. In a world buzzing with incessant action, being asleep seems almost like a crime on both counts. Society demands high productivity above all, pushing people into a desperate daily rush to either make both ends meet or to succeed, and they literally lose sleep over their economic life situations. The Agewell Foundation survey found that one of the main reasons for troubled sleep among the elderly is inter-generational conflict owing to financial and interpersonal differences. The Great Indian Sleep Scorecard by sleep solutions company Wakefit found that, in 2024, a whopping 88 per cent respondents gazed at their mobile phone screens before bed, and as many as 54 per cent reported staying up beyond bed time to consume social media and OTT content. Cause and effect get bound up in a vicious circle. A sleep-deprived population, ironically, ends up being the worst thing possible for productivity.

It also impacts us at levels much less abstract, and rather more brutal. Sleep abnormality, in any form, affects everything from cardiovascular to cognitive health. A new study, where the National Institutes of Health in the US collaborated with fitness app Fitbit and Google, throws fresh light on sleep deprivation and its impact on a wide array of health outcomes. Among the key findings is that sleep irregularity and deprivation have a high correlation to high blood pressure, psychiatric disorders and migraines. It also showed that balanced sleep plays a crucial role in a person's mental health and emotional wellbeing. As a country, therefore, conducting a sleep audit must become a public health priority.

In this week's cover story, Senior Associate Editor Sonali Acharjee awakens us from this slumber of good sense. The first lesson is that we simply cannot ignore sleep: we must educate ourselves about what it is, how its different stages perform vital functions, and what its absence can do to you. Many of us know the basics, but are still unable to act on it. For, sleeplessness is no longer just a choice, it has become a chronic disorder. Once we have the diagnosis, we come to the stage where we cure ourselves. In these pages, find not only a clear textual and graphical explanation of sleep and its various disorders, but also the promising new lines of therapy. There's a whole line of gadgets out there that you can use: from simple implements like sleep buds that cancel out noise, electronic trackers that trace patterns of disturbance, devices that keep temperatures at the optimum, speakers to play white noise, and devices that help with snoring. Material help is at hand with weighted blankets, breathable pyjamas, comfort mattresses and even smart pillows. There are exercises that help bring on quality sleep by lowering the breathing rate. Home remedies like chamomile tea may not yet have scientific backing, but no harm done if it works for you. If all else fails, there's a range of medication, including the melatonin gummies that have become all the rage.

The best way out is to take control of yourself with discipline and self-care. Most of all, as night falls, it's time to embrace an idea in bed. It's called sleep hygiene. Nearly everyone has by now heard of what should be avoided: alcohol, caffeine and any electronic device that emits blue light. If you don't wish to walk into a biological breakdown with your eyes wide open, accept that there's almost nothing in the usual run of daily life that can't wait till tomorrow morning. If you're reading this at night, let it be the last word. Good night!



(Aroon Purie)

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**